The point about the conversions may have stung the Jesuits and they ‘began to suspect that he was intending to found a new religion with matter taken from all the existing systems’. Jahangir also talked about this aspect of his father in his memoir when he wrote: ‘[T]he professors of various faiths had room in the broad expanse of his incomparable sway. This was different from the practice in other realms for in Persia there is room for Shias only and in Turkey, India (non-Mughal) and Turan there is room for Sunnis only.’

Dismayed and defeated, the Jesuits decided to leave the Mughal court, not wishing to give Akbar ‘the pearls of the Gospel to tread and crush under his feet’. They asked Abu’l Fazl with some mystification why Akbar desired their presence at the court so passionately when it was clear now he had no intention of becoming a Christian. ‘The King, having a desire for all kinds of knowledge, and liking to show his greatness,’ replied Abu’l Fazl succinctly, ‘[is] delighted to have at his court people of all nations.’ ‘My father always associated with the learned of every creed and religion’, agreed Jahangir, ‘especially with Pandits and the learned of India’. As for Akbar himself, when Acquaviva told him he was planning to leave, he replied with simple sincerity: ‘I love you, Father, and rejoice to have you near me; for you have taught me many things which have pleased me more than all I have learnt from others.’ In a letter to the Jesuit mission in Goa, Akbar admitted that, ‘the Almighty, through his eternal favours and perpetual grace, had turned (his) heart in such a way as continuously to create a craving for God’ while Jahangir wrote about Akbar that he ‘never for one moment forgot God’.

The pearls that Akbar did collect, despite the Jesuits’ misgivings, contained multitudes. They could not be constrained within the rigorous limits of the Jesuit doctrine, for Akbar’s kingdom contained almost limitless ways of worshipping the divine. It was probably just as well that the Jesuits had left by the time Akbar was taking part in the ceremonies that Badauni wrote about with despair. There were masses of people, wrote Badauni, who ‘stood every morning opposite to the window, near which His Majesty used to pray to the sun, and declared that they had made vows not to rinse their mouth, nor to eat and drink, before they had seen the blessed countenance of the Emperor. And every evening there was a regular Court assembly of needy Hindus and Musalmans, all sorts of people, men and women, healthy and sick, a queer gathering and a most terrible crowd. No sooner had His